



REFUGEES

Life for the Mayans is a constant struggle for survival, and many have suffered hardship and death in their attempts to avoid being forced into mainstream society. Persecution was particularly bad in the early 1980s, when the then military government set out to eliminate them. Some 60,000 Mayans fled to safety in refugee camps in Mexico. Today, they are returning to Guatemala, but their safety is uncertain and much of their land has been seized.



STREET CHILDREN

Guatemala City is home to growing numbers of so-called street children. Forced to leave home because of poverty and abuse, children live in small groups and survive through crime, by begging, and selling whatever they can find. Recently, human rights groups such as Amnesty International have drawn attention to their plight.

BELIZE

LYING ON THE CARIBBEAN COAST, Belize is both an old and a new country. Ancient ruins dot the landscape, reminders of its Mayan history, but the country itself only achieved full independence in 1981. For many years, Belize was a British colony, the only one in Central America. English is the official language, but Belizeans are descended from several ethnic groups – Caribs, Africans, Mayans, Asians, and Europeans – and many people speak a Creole or African dialect. Caribbean foods and music are popular, and the country is famous for its wildlife.

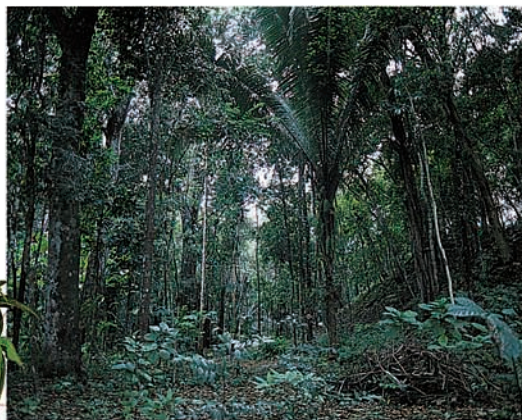


CORAL REEF

A chain of coral reefs, dotted with small sandy islands called cayes, runs 180 miles (290 km) along the coastline of Belize. It is the world's second largest barrier reef, after Australia's, and is home to turtles, sea anemones, and spiny lobsters, as well as a wonderful array of tropical fish. The clear, warm water attracts divers from around the world.



Flooding and hurricanes can cause serious problems along the coast of Belize, so a new capital, Belmopan, has been built farther inland than Belize City, the old capital.



DEEP IN THE FOREST

Dense tropical rain forest covers half of Belize's land area. Rosewood, and other products from the forest, such as chicle, used to make chewing gum, and kapok, a silky cotton from the giant Ceiba tree, are important to the economy. So, too, are the increasing number of citrus groves. But cultivation is limited. Much of the rain forest is protected and provides a rich habitat for plants and animals.



BELMOPAN

In 1961, a massive hurricane and tidal wave devastated the coastal capital, Belize City. In 1970, a new capital, Belmopan, was built 50 miles (80 km) inland to protect it from tropical storms. Although people and businesses are gradually moving to the new capital, Belize City remains the country's most populated city.

FOREST WILDLIFE

The forests are filled with an amazing variety of wildlife. Jaguars, tapirs, howler monkeys, and coatimundi are just a few of the world's endangered species still thriving in the forests of Belize. Butterflies and tropical birds fly through the trees. And there are 250 different types of orchid, including the black orchid, Belize's national flower.

Toucans live in the treetops so they can fly around the open areas.

The howler monkey defends its part of the rain forest with a noisy howl.



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